

FIRST CLASS

TRAVELLING IN STYLE

PARADISE FOUND

A new family looking for *SPIRITUAL REBOOT* get what they needed at the thought-of-everything IDYLL of Song Saa in Cambodia.

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In some ways, Song Saa found us. Five months after having our baby, Max, my husband and I were stumbling out of the new-parent haze: sleepless nights, the constant feeds and nappy changes. We desperately needed to reconnect. Our friend was doing publicity for a gorgeous new resort in Cambodia owned by an Australian couple, Rory and Melita Hunter, and asked if we would like to come and visit. I had one free week left before returning to work. We booked it. It was meant to be.

Two weeks later we are on a speedboat, careering through the Gulf of Thailand towards a postcard pair of islands known as Song Saa, Khmer for “the sweethearts”. Their verdant curves rise companionably from the aquamarine depths. These ►



The villa interior, with views out across the water.

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islands are but Lilliputian specks in an archipelago of 61 islands, just 45 minutes by speedboat off Sihanoukville on the south coast of Cambodia. Back in the 1960s, before the devastation of the Khmer Rouge, these sherbet-sanded beaches were known as the Saint-Tropez of Asia, visited by Jacqueline Kennedy and Catherine Deneuve. Now, with Song Saa leading the charge, the region looks set to dazzle again.

At the jetty is our barefoot welcoming committee: Rory and Melita with their four-year-old adopted son Naryth, general manager Greg Williams and several Cambodian staff dressed in a chic, relaxed uniform of fisherman's pants and loose linen shirts. We are led to our palatial over-water villa, where we find an infinity pool flanked by white day beds, a table and chairs made of driftwood and steps winding down to the ocean. The castaway aesthetic continues inside – with bamboo roots, seed pods, furniture and artwork made from repurposed fishing boats and organic treasures sitting seamlessly alongside such five-star comforts as an espresso machine, an iPad pre-loaded with soothing music, a Bose sound system, a four-poster bed framed by filmy muslin curtains, and an immense stone bath with views into the blue vastness. On our kitchen counter is a piece of hand-carved driftwood containing

limes, mint, basil, sugar syrup and vodka with a handwritten recipe for lemongrass *vodkajitos*. We lie on the day bed with Max and watch the fishing boats splutter home as a tangerine sun sinks into the inky sea.

That night, over a delicious Khmer meal in their villa, Rory and Melita tell us the story of Song Saa. Rory had left a job in a Phnom Penh ad agency to work with Melita renovating French-Cambodian houses for expats. Just married and island-hopping through the archipelago, they stumbled upon Song Saa. Out of the blue, the family who owned the islands offered to sell; fishing was slow and they had been thinking of moving to the mainland anyway. Back then, Song Saa was no postcard. Locals had been dumping rubbish in a tip in the centre of the island for more than 30 years. But Rory and Melita saw potential. The dilapidated village that the family lived in was built out over the water. It gave them an idea. “We realised that if these wooden shacks were still standing after all these years they must be well protected,” says Rory. This would be the perfect site for a resort with Maldives-style over-water villas. It's rare to find such a tsunami-proof spot like that in Asia. They couldn't pass this chance up. Two years later, after much expense and negotiating with the government, the two Crusoe-style isles were theirs on a 99-year

lease with the proviso they develop them as a tourism venture. But just as they started working on their plans, Melita was diagnosed with cancer – there was a tumour the size of a golf ball in her uterus. They dropped everything and flew home to Australia.

The doctor prescribed chemotherapy with a radical hysterectomy. Melita had other ideas: “I asked him to push out the surgery; I knew I could heal myself with time. I saw my mum die of cancer at 45. I wasn't prepared to go down that road.”

For six weeks she saw a kinesiologist, practised yoga, meditation and *qigong*, and had a naturopath devise an eating plan. “We made cancer soup every night. We made it fun,” remembers Rory. When it was time for surgery, Melita convinced the oncologist to only take her uterus out. It was sent off to pathology and they waited two anxious weeks for the results. To the doctor's disbelief, the cancer had disappeared. “I was given a whole new lease on life,” Melita says. “[We said] we can do anything we want.”

Back in Cambodia to realise their dreams, they started by adopting Naryth, “a cheeky and divine little soul”, from a local orphanage. Then it was on to their next baby, Song Saa. “From that moment on, life was all about giving back,” Melita recalls. Everything they did had an air of thanks about it.

In developing Song Saa, the couple adopted the maxim “luxury that treads lightly”. They work closely with the local village, employing and training many of the villagers as staff and teaching them about waste management as well as sustainable fishing and farming practices. They have six conservation staff, including a biologist, naturalist and marine scientist, to develop Cambodia's first protected marine area extending 200 metres from the reefs around Song Saa, along with various programs to protect unique local fauna such as bats, hornbills, sea eagles and owls.

We walk back to our villa in complete awe. Not just of Melita's courage and creativity or Rory's infectious energy and warm, easy way, but of their obvious passion and commitment to Cambodia. The sustainable practices being put into action on Song Saa are so much more than the half-hearted greenwashing going on at other enviro-resorts. And it's all done with such style. This is eco-chic on steroids.

The next four days is the stuff of dreams. We lose ourselves in books and drink champagne at midday. One day we take the boat out to the impossibly white Five Mile Beach and coax Max into his first swim as the staff set up a grand picnic of wicker baskets, parasols, seafood and a crisp sauvignon blanc.

Monsoonal afternoons are spent being coddled and massaged by Song Saa's



Where the Song Saa infinity pool meets the Gulf of Thailand.



A picnic under the parasols on the floury Five Mile Beach.

incredible spa staff. Taking place in the two “Spa Sanctuary” villas, the treatments are infused with the Buddhist tradition of *metta bhavana*, or loving kindness, and feature the Ila range of organic cosmetics. Each treatment is a spiritual experience. Along the walkway to the treatment sanctuary, a Buddhist prayer gong chimes meditatively as a

curl of incense lures us into a somnambulant state. Hours pass in slow motion and gentle dreams lap at the consciousness.

After sunset every evening, a babysitter arrives to keep an eye on Max while we dine at the resort's restaurants or enjoy a “destination dinner” in a secret location somewhere on the island, such as by the pool or a private stretch of beach. Song Saa's executive chef Neil Wager (from the Seychelles' North Island resort) has enquired

about our tastes beforehand and personalised the menus. When he joined Song Saa, he journeyed around Cambodia picking up traditional recipes and native herbs to create his own spin on Khmer food (which is similar to Thai, but lighter). His meals of fresh seafood and locally sourced ingredients arrive dressed to impress on banana leaves or flourished with fine blooms. As we linger over a fish

amok curry or tender beef *lok lok*, Damien and I find each other again as the moon shoots tendrils of silver over the ocean.

Adding to the fantasy aspect of it all, guests are not required to sign a single bill. Everything except spa treatments and some activities are included in the resort's “one price per villa” policy. The tariff includes all food and drink (my weaning of Max was well timed), a daily laundry service, well-stocked mini-bar, WiFi and free international calls to home to find out what's happening in the real world.

When it is time to leave, the staff packs our bags so we can spend our last precious hours by the pool. It's details like this that make Song Saa so special: returning to your spotless room to find edible treats and handwritten notes and the bath filled with tropical flowers. Everything about Song Saa feels personal, as if some greater force is ordaining you to have the most incredible holiday of your life. Which is what we did. As we board the boat and farewell our new friends Rory and Melita we agree that we had, indeed, found paradise. Or perhaps it found us. ■

Go to www.songsaa.com.

URBAN REMEDY

Enrich your Khmer experience with a visit to Cambodia's fascinating cities. The capital and business centre of Cambodia, Phnom Penh has a growing foodie and arts scene, while Siem Reap's ancient Angkor temples should be on everyone's bucket list. Raffles Hotel Le Royal in Phnom Penh is a grand oasis fringed by palms and monkey pod trees. A fusion of Khmer, art deco and French colonial style, the 1920s-built hotel is still as charming today as it was when it played host to stars like Charlie Chaplin and Jacqueline Kennedy. Raffles Grand Hotel d'Angkor Siem Reap is spread over six hectares of lush tropical gardens only eight kilometres from Angkor Wat. After busy mornings exploring the temples, temper the tropical heat with chilled towels and icy fruit skewers by the magnificent pool or linger for high tea in the lemongrass-scented lobby, a cool respite from the soupy humidity beyond its walls. Go to www.affles.com/phnompenh and www.affles.com/siemreap.

